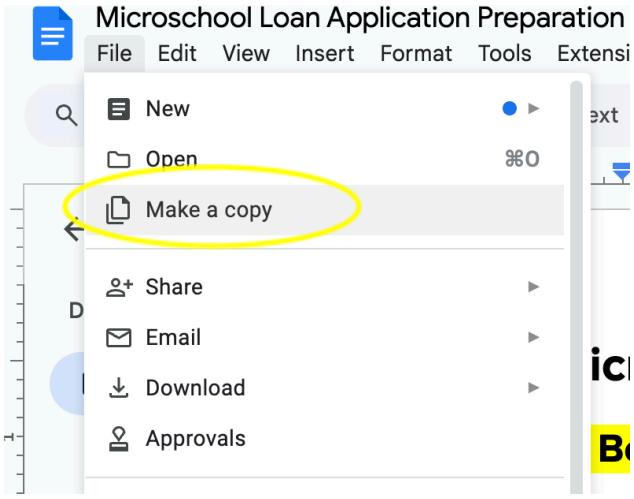
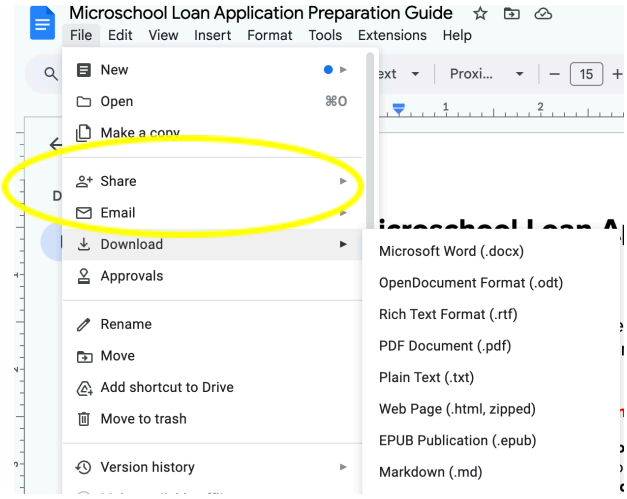
Microschool Loan Application Preparation Guide

This is not the actual application.

➡️ Before You Begin

Copy this Google document *or* download it for Word to draft your short answer responses and gather documents before you begin the official application when it opens in July.





1. **Confirm eligibility**
2. **Read the application, pull together materials, and start working on the financial model**
   - **Go through the document checklist to get all your attachments together**
   - **Contact references**
   - **Begin drafting short answer questions**
3. **Finish completing short answers; Complete your financial model**
4. **Rename files, spellcheck/grammar check short answers**

With everything prepared, completing the application should take about an hour. Please review everything once more before submitting.

💡 **Pro tip:** Work through this guide section by section, checking items off as you go. Don't feel like you need to complete everything in one sitting.

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📂 Required Uploads

Reference the Eligibility Checklist in your Loan Prep Guide for the most up-to-date checklist

School Leadership & Contact

Please provide information about the individual leading the school. This person should be responsible for the school's strategic and operational decisions and may also be the primary contact for this loan application.

School Leader Information:

- **Full Name** (First Name, Last Name)
- **Title**
- **Email Address** (example@example.com)
- **Phone Number** (Please enter a 10-digit number without spaces or punctuation (e.g., 5551234567).)
- **LinkedIn Profile** (Please enter the complete URL, including https://)
- **Are you the founder of the school?**
- **Are you the individual completing this application?**
    - If no, please share the name and title of the person completing this application.

Co-Founder Information:

- **Does your school have a co-founder?**

If yes:
If your school has a co-founder, please include their information below. For any long-form questions about leadership or vision, you're welcome to respond however feels most natural, whether from your individual perspective, your co-founder's, or a shared response that reflects your journey together. We're interested in understanding your story, however you choose to tell it.

- **Full Name** (First Name, Last Name)
- **Title**
- **Email Address** (example@example.com)
- **Phone Number** (Please enter a 10-digit number without spaces or punctuation (e.g., 5551234567).)
- **LinkedIn Profile** (Please enter the complete URL, including https://)

Leadership Story: Your Journey

While the applicant is the school entity, the success of any microschool depends heavily on the tenacity, vision, and preparedness of its founder or founding team. This section focuses on the individual(s) guiding the school through launch and early operations.

Applicants are encouraged to share relevant experiences—formal or informal—that demonstrate readiness to lead. These may include prior roles in education, entrepreneurial efforts, leadership training, school visits, licensure, fundraising, or lessons learned through direct experience. All credible preparation counts. The goal is to understand who is behind the school, what has equipped them for this responsibility, and what fuels their long-term commitment to succeed.

SHORT ANSWER QUESTIONS

- ➡ **What life experiences, challenges, or moments of inspiration led you to launch this microschool?** (0/250 words)
- ➡ **What training or professional development have you completed to prepare for this work? (Think about formal or informal fellowships, courses, and/or programs.)** (0/150 words)
- ➡ **Have you raised funds to support your school? (If you haven't fundraised yet, feel free to leave this section blank or note any plans for the future.)**(0/100 words)
- ➡ **Who are your school's champions, and what gives them confidence in your leadership?** (0/150 words)*
- ➡ **What is your contingency or succession plan if you need to step away for any of the abovementioned reasons?** (0/150 words)

Applicant Details

- **Applicant Name** (This should be the school's name and legal entity; the borrower listed on the loan document will be this name.)
- **Do you have a d/b/a?** (doing business as)
    - **d/b/a** (if applicable)
- **EIN**
- **School Website** (A website is strongly encouraged as part of your school's professional presence. If you do not yet have one, you may provide a social media profile or a planning document link (e.g., Google Doc or Slide Deck).
- **Street Address**
- **City**
- **County**
- **State**
- **Zipcode**

Affiliations

Are you affiliated with any microschool networks, membership organizations, funders, or incubators? (Select all that apply.)
🖱️ Hold Ctrl (Windows) or Cmd (Mac) to select multiple options. 📱 On mobile: Tap each option to add it.

- ☐ 4.0
- ☐ Ambleside Schools International
- ☐ Acton
- ☐ Agile Learning Centers
- ☐ Apogee Strong
- ☐ ASU Microschool Fellowship
- ☐ Black Microschools of Atlanta
- ☐ Changemaker Microschools
- ☐ Chesterton Academies
- ☐ Colossal Academy
- ☐ The Drexel Fund
- ☐ EdChoice
- ☐ Embark Mississippi
- ☐ Excel
- ☐ Fuel OKC
- ☐ Getting Smart
- ☐ Herzog Foundation
- ☐ Indiana Microschool Network
- ☐ Iowa Association of Christian Schools
- ☐ KaiPod Learning
- ☐ Kennesaw (Hybrid Schools Society)
- ☐ Kind Academy
- ☐ Liberated Learners
- ☐ Microschool Solutions
- ☐ National Microschooling Center
- ☐ Ohio Christian Education Network
- ☐ Permissionless Education
- ☐ Prenda
- ☐ Primer
- ☐ Rebel Educator
- ☐ Reform Alliance
- ☐ Rock by Rock
- ☐ San Juan Diego Institute
- ☐ Soaring Education
- ☐ Spark Microschools
- ☐ Transcend
- ☐ VELA Founder Network
- ☐ Wildflower Schools
- ☐ YASS
- ☐ Not affiliated with a program
- ☐ A program is not listed

  - **If "a program is not listed" is selected.**
    - **Which organizations did we miss?** We want to recognize all the great partners in this work.

School Structure & Compliance

This section covers legal entity status and is important because it helps underwriters know the regulatory frameworks that apply to your business structure and organization.

- **What is the legal structure of your school in your state?**
  - ☐ Corporation
  - ☐ General Partnership
  - ☐ LLC (Limited Liability Company)
  - ☐ LLP (Limited Liability Partnership)
  - ☐ Nonprofit Corporation

- **What is your school's tax classification?**
  - ☐ C Corp
  - ☐ Disregarded Entity (Single-Member LLC)
  - ☐ Nonprofit - 501(c)(3) approved
  - ☐ Nonprofit - 501(c)(3) pending

- ☐ Nonprofit - through a fiscal sponsor
- ☐ Partnership
- ☐ S Corp
    - ***If yes to nonprofit approved***
        - ☐ What date were you approved by the IRS?
    - ***If yes to nonprofit pending***
        - ☐ What date did you submit your 1023 application to the IRS?
    - ***If yes to "through a fiscal sponsor"***
        - ☐ What entity is your fiscal sponsor?

- What is your microschool type? (Select all that apply.)
    - ☐ Charter School
    - ☐ Homeschool Enrichment Program
    - ☐ Learning Pod
    - ☐ Private School
    - ☐ Supplemental Program
    - ☐ Tutoring Center
    - ☐ Other
        - ***If yes to charter school:***
            - ☐ **Who is your authorizer?**
            - ☐ **What date were you authorized?** (Date you received your charter)
        - ***If yes to private school***
            - ☐ **Are you accredited?**
            - ☐ **Who is your accreditor?**
            - ☐ **What date were you accredited?**

Educational Program & Model

- **Which best describes your school's model or program? (Select all that apply.)**
  🖱️ Hold Ctrl (Windows) or Cmd (Mac) to select multiple options. 📱 On mobile: Tap each option to add it.
  - ☐ Agriculture Based
  - ☐ AI Focus
  - ☐ Arts Integrated
  - ☐ Career and Technical Program
  - ☐ Classical Education
  - ☐ Dual Language
  - ☐ Entrepreneurship Focused
  - ☐ Faith Based
  - ☐ Hybrid Learning
  - ☐ Microschool Network Affiliate
  - ☐ Montessori Inspired
  - ☐ Nature Based
  - ☐ Neurodiverse Affirming
  - ☐ Outdoor Education
  - ☐ Project-Based Learning
  - ☐ Reggio Emilia Inspired
  - ☐ Social Emotional Learning
  - ☐ STEM Focused
  - ☐ Waldorf Inspired
  - ☐ Other
  - ☐

- **How do you primarily group or enroll students?**
  - ☐ By grade level
  - ☐ By age
  - ☐ By multi-age or mixed-grade bands

- **What grade level(s) will your school serve in Fall 2025? (Select all that apply.)**
  🖱️ Hold Ctrl (Windows) or Cmd (Mac) to select multiple options. 📱 On mobile: Tap each option to add it.
  - ☐ K
  - ☐ 1st
  - ☐ 2nd
  - ☐ 3rd
  - ☐ 4th
  - ☐ 5th
  - ☐ 6th
  - ☐ 7th
  - ☐ 8th
  - ☐ 9th
  - ☐ 10th
  - ☐ 11th
  - ☐ 12th

- **Do you enroll children under the age of 5?**
  - ☐ **If yes, please describe your program. (How many children? Are you a licensed early childhood provider?)**

- **What ages of students will your school serve in Fall 2025? (Select all that apply.)**
  - ☐ 5
  - ☐ 6
  - ☐ 7
  - ☐ 8
  - ☐ 9
  - ☐ 10
  - ☐ 11
  - ☐ 12
  - ☐ 13
  - ☐ 14
  - ☐ 15
  - ☐ 16
  - ☐ 17
  - ☐ 18

- **What grade levels or ages of students are included in your total enrollment projection in your financial model? (2029-30)**

SHORT ANSWER

- ➡ **What is your mission statement? (500 characters / 75–100 words)**
- ➡ **What makes your school distinct? Tell us what unique strengths, values, or lived experiences shape your design, and what specific problem you're solving that other schools aren't. (0/250)**
- ➡ **How will your school measure student learning and growth? Please describe the tools, assessments, or methods you plan to use to understand students' progress. You may include academic benchmarks, portfolios, performance tasks, formative assessments, summative assessments, or other approaches. (0/250 words)**

Schedule & Calendar

- What is your first day of school in the 2025-26 school year? _____
- What is your last day of school in the 2025-26 school year? _____

- What is your school's operating schedule?
  - **Days per week**
    - ☐ 1
    - ☐ 2
    - ☐ 3
    - ☐ 4
    - ☐ 5
    - ☐ 6
    - ☐ 7
  - **Hours per day**
    - ☐ 1
    - ☐ 2
    - ☐ 3
    - ☐ 4
    - ☐ 5
    - ☐ 6
    - ☐ 7
    - ☐ 8
    - ☐ 9
    - ☐ 1

Enrollment

Strong enrollment demand is a key indicator of viability and impact

- **What is your enrollment goal? _____**
  (What is the maximum number of students you envision enrolling in your school?)

- **What year do you expect your school to achieve the enrollment goal?**
  - ☐ We've achieved it already
  - ☐ 2025-26
  - ☐ 2026-27
  - ☐ 2027-28
  - ☐ 2028-29
  - ☐ 2029-30
  - ☐ After 2030

- **2025-26 Projected Enrollment**
  - ☐ How many students do you expect to have enrolled in Fall 2025?

- **2025-26 Waitlist Count**
  - ☐ How many students are currently on your waitlist for Fall 2025?

For Schools Operating in 2024-25:

- **2024-25 Enrollment**
  - ☐ What was your 2024 actual enrollment count?
- **2024-25 Waitlist Count**
  - ☐ How many students were on the waitlist for a seat at your school last year?

Student Retention
(Only for schools with an operating history.)

Understanding Student Retention

Retention tells us how many students choose to stay with your school from one year to the next. However, not all retention metrics are created equally.

Here's the definition we use for clarity and consistency:

Student retention is the percentage of students enrolled on the **first day of the prior school year** and then returned on the **first day of the following school year**.

Retention Rate (%) = (# of students who returned on the first day this year ÷ # of students enrolled on the first day last year) × 100

- **What was your student retention rate from 2023-24 to 2024-25?**
  - ☐ What percentage of students enrolled in 2024-25 who started the school year with you in 2023-24
- **What is your projected student retention rate from 2024-25 to 2025-26?**
  - ☐ What percentage of students are you projecting will enroll in 2025-26 who started the school year with you in 2024-25?

💡 **Note:** Your school may need to calculate an **adjusted retention rate** to account for terminal grades (such as 5th, 8th, or 12th in a traditional setting) where students naturally exit the school. These students should not be included in the returner denominator when calculating year-to-year student retention.

Adjusted Retention Formula:

Retention Rate = (Students re-enrolled in Year 2 ÷ Eligible returning students from Year 1, excluding terminal grades) × 100

SHORT ANSWER

➡ **What evidence do you have that gives you confidence in your 2025-26 enrollment projection?** (0/150 words)

Verifying Enrollment with Family Deposits

(Only for Year 0 & Year 1 schools; 2024 launch or planning to open August/September 2025)

👪 Demonstrating Family Commitment

To help us underwrite Year 0 and Year 1 schools (e.g., schools opening this fall or launched in 2024) without retention data, we ask that schools collect at least a **$25 deposit** for each projected new student. This step helps show that families are truly planning to enroll, and will be verified later through Plaid.

- **Have you begun collecting deposits to demonstrate family commitment for new students planning to enroll in Fall 2025?**

- **How many deposits of at least $25 have you collected from committed families to date?** (1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21+)

➡ **If no deposits have been collected, please use this space to explain your unique context or alternative evidence of family commitment.** (0/150 words)

Facility Information

- **What type of space will your school operate in during the 2025-26 school year?**
  - ☐ Church or religious facility
  - ☐ Commercial space (e.g., retail, office, coworking)
  - ☐ Community center or nonprofit facility
  - ☐ Existing school (shared use or sublease)
  - ☐ Dedicated facility (exclusive use by your school)
  - ☐ Public building (e.g., library, municipal space)
  - ☐ Other (please specify)

Select the option that best describes your current or planned agreement for use of space.

- **What is your facility status?**
  - ☐ We own the facility
  - ☐ We have a signed lease agreement
  - ☐ We have identified a facility, but cannot proceed until funding is secured
  - ☐ We are actively searching for a facility

- **When does your lease expire?** _____
- **What is the monthly payment?**_____
- **What is the facility's maximum enrollment capacity?**_____
- **What is the facility's total interior square feet?** _____
- **Has your facility passed a fire inspection?** **Yes** **No**
  - ☐ ***If Yes***
    - ***Date of inspection***

➡ **If you haven't secured a facility or you don't have a lease in place for the upcoming school year, what's your plan to finalize your space and sign a lease?** (0/150 words)

Financials

Please provide us with information about the sources of funding you plan to use to operate your school, which will help us better understand your financial model.

- **What month is the start of your fiscal year?**

  - ☐ January
  - ☐ February
  - ☐ March
  - ☐ April
  - ☐ May
  - ☐ June
  - ☐ July
  - ☐ August
  - ☐ September
  - ☐ October
  - ☐ November
  - ☐ December

- **What are your primary sources of revenue? (Select all that apply.)**
  - ☐ Tuition is paid directly by families.
  - ☐ Public funding (e.g., charter school per pupil, Education Savings Accounts, vouchers, or tax-credit scholarships)
  - ☐ Grants or donations
  - ☐ Private scholarships

- **What categories of public funding are included in your operating budget? (Select all that apply.)**
  - ☐ Pupil per pupil funding (only applies to charter schools)
  - ☐ Education Savings Accounts (ESAs)
  - ☐ Homeschool Assistance Funds (e.g., Florida PEP, Oklahoma Equal Opportunity Fund)
  - ☐ Voucher program
  - ☐ Tax-credit scholarships (e.g., Alabama SGO, Ohio EdChoice, etc.)

- **What is your school's current status with receiving public education funding?**
  - ☐ We are an approved provider and can directly receive public funds (e.g., ESA, voucher, scholarship)
  - ☐ Families use public funds to pay us directly (we don't receive the funds)
  - ☐ We are in the process of applying and awaiting approval
  - ☐ We are not approved yet, but we plan to apply
  - ☐ We are not eligible to apply in our state
  - ☐ Other

- **What is the average annual tuition per student in 2025-26? _____**

- **What is your tuition billing schedule?**
  - ☐ Annual (full payment due at the start of the year)
  - ☐ Quarterly (aligned with ESA disbursement)

- ☐ Monthly
- ☐ Other

- **Do parents sign a tuition contract at the beginning of each school year?**

Please fill in a snapshot of your revenue, expenses, and net income for applicable years. Please enter 0s for years that don't apply to your school.

	2023-24	**2024-25**	**2025-26* (Projected)**
Revenue			
Expenses			
Net Income			

- **Is the school leader receiving a salary in the 2025-26 school year?**
- **Does your school currently have any outstanding loans or financial obligations you are actively repaying?**

➡ **If yes, please provide details of any outstanding loans your school or organization currently holds**. For each loan, include: the date the loan closed; original loan amount; loan term (in months or years); interest rate (fixed or variable); maturity date; current outstanding balance; monthly payment amount; repayment frequency (monthly, quarterly, etc.); purpose of the loan; name of the lender; collateral pledged, if any; whether a personal guarantee was required (yes or no); and any prepayment terms, including penalties or restrictions. If you have more than one loan, please provide this information for each. (200 words)

➡ **How does your school manage cash flow?**

- **(1) If you are a new school launching soon, how will you manage expenses in the early months before full revenue begins?**
- **(2) For operating schools, how do you manage revenue fluctuations with public funding or tuition payments?**
  Please include any strategies, reserves, or funding sources you rely on. (0/150 words)

Loan Request

All loans are offered in **$5,000 increments** and carry a **3% fixed interest rate**. Payments are made **quarterly**, and the repayment schedule is **graduated**:

- **Year 1:** Interest-only
- **Year 2:** Partial principal + interest
- **Years 3–5:** Full amortization (larger quarterly payments)

First quarterly payment is due October 1, 2025. All payments are made via ACH debit.

Loan Amount	Term	Year 1 Payment	Year 2 Payment	Years 3+ Payment
$5,000.00	3 years	$37.50/qtr	$341.89/qtr	$959.90/qtr
$10,000.00	3 years	$75.00/qtr	$683.78/qtr	$1,919.80/qtr
$15,000.00	4 years	$112.50/qtr	$712.14/qtr	$1,625.30/qtr
$20,000.00	4 years	$150.00/qtr	$949.51/qtr	$2,167.07/qtr
$25,000.00	4 years	$187.50/qtr	$1,186.89/qtr	$2,708.84/qtr
$30,000.00	5 years	$225.00/qtr	$1,110.88/qtr	$2,310.15/qtr
$35,000.00	5 years	$262.50/qtr	$1,296.03/qtr	$2,695.18/qtr
$40,000.00	5 years	$300.00/qtr	$1,481.18/qtr	$3,080.21/qtr
$45,000.00	5 years	$337.50/qtr	$1,666.32/qtr	$3,465.23/qtr
$50,000.00	5 years	$375.00/qtr	$1,851.47/qtr	$3,850.26/qtr

Your financial model must demonstrate that your school can afford this loan.

That means:

✅ The full loan, not just interest, also known as debt service, must be reflected in your financial model alongside all other expenses.
✅ Your model must show a positive net-income across all operating years
✅ Your repayment plan must be aligned with your enrollment assumptions, tuition billing schedule, and revenue sources (e.g., ESA payments, fundraising).

Choose a level of funding that fits your actual financial trajectory.

- **What loan amount are you requesting?**
  - ☐ $5,000
  - ☐ $10,000
  - ☐ $15,000
  - ☐ $20,000
  - ☐ $25,000
  - ☐ $30,000
  - ☐ $35,000
  - ☐ $40,000
  - ☐ $45,000
  - ☐ $50,000

Use of Funds

- **How do you plan to use the loan funds? (Select all that apply.)**
  🖱️ Hold Ctrl (Windows) or Cmd (Mac) to select multiple options. 📱 On mobile: Tap each option to add it.
  - ☐ Facility Improvements
  - ☐ Furniture & Fixtures
  - ☐ Curriculum & Materials
  - ☐ Supplies
  - ☐ Marketing & Outreach
  - ☐ Licensing & Permits
  - ☐ Rent
  - ☐ Salaries & Stipends
  - ☐ Training & Professional Development
  - ☐ Other

What will this loan unlock, and how will the funds be used in the coming months?
This fund exists to help schools take action, whether launching new seats, securing a facility, or making essential investments to serve families now.

SHORT ANSWER

➡ **Please describe how you plan to use the funds and when you expect to spend them. Understanding your priorities and timeline helps us make the most informed and supportive decision. (0/150 words)**

Character References

Please share two references who can speak to your leadership, integrity, and commitment to being a trustworthy leader and borrower for this program.

If your application moves past the initial review, we'll contact your references promptly, so please let them know to expect a call or email from us.

We also ask that you upload a letter of support from each reference on the next page. Family members aren't eligible, but your enrolled families, community partners, or trusted champions are. We encourage you to select people who can speak to your character and leadership.

Reference #1

- **Name** (First Name, Last Name)
- **How do you know this person?**
- **Email** (example@example.com)
- **Phone Number** (Please enter a number to reach this person during business hours.)

Reference #2

- **Name** (First Name, Last Name)
- **How do you know this person?**
- **Email** (example@example.com)
- **Phone Number** (Please enter a valid phone number.)

📂 Required Uploads

Please reference the Upload Checklist in your Loan Prep Guide for the most updated document list.

How to name each file (required):
`[SchoolName]_[DocumentType]`

Examples

- `BrightFutureAcademy_FinancialModel.MMDDYYY.xlsx`
- `BrightFutureAcademy_COI.MMDDYYY.pdf`
- `BrightFutureAcademy_SignedLease.MMDDYYYY.pdf`

💡 Tips

- **Use underscores**, no spaces.
- Keep DocumentType short and match the checklist labels (e.g., `Articles`, `GoodStanding`, `Waitlist`).
- One document per file. **Please don't bundle different items together.**
- Accepted formats: PDF for scanned docs, XLS/XLSX for models, and DOC/DOCX for text files.